Teaching Statement

Chandra Dhakal, PhD

I believe data is only as valuable as the policy it informs — and students learn econometrics best when every method answers a question that matters. My teaching transforms students into independent researchers capable of producing evidence-based insights, through research-integrated pedagogy built on four principles: active learning with real data, inclusive excellence, methodological transparency, and policy communication.

Active Learning Through Real Data

Students in my courses work with authentic datasets to answer substantive policy questions, not textbook exercises. As instructor of record for *Analytical and Computational Tools for Applied Economics* at the University of Georgia, I taught econometric methods and computational skills in Stata and R using Nielsen retail scanner data and the Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System — the same data underlying my published research. Students cleaned large transaction files, estimated demand systems, and presented findings as policy briefs, experiencing the full arc from raw data to decision-relevant evidence. As a teaching assistant for Principles of Microeconomics and Futures and Options Markets, I learned to meet students where they are: grounding abstract theory in concrete examples before building to formal methods.

Beyond the university classroom, I design and lead international training-of-trainers workshops in health economics and decision modeling. In Cebu, Philippines (January 2025), I trained 37 participants from 19 countries — health economists and ministry officials with widely varying quantitative backgrounds — on Markov models, microsimulation, and cost-effectiveness analysis. Across the Bloomberg Philanthropies Data for Health Initiative, I have trained 100+ economists and policymakers worldwide. Teaching heterogeneous adult learners across cultures sharpened my ability to scaffold complex material: every workshop pairs concise theory with guided, hands-on modeling so participants leave having built working models themselves. I bring the same learning-by-doing ethos to undergraduate and graduate classrooms.

Inclusive Excellence

My own trajectory — from Nepal to Texas to Georgia — taught me that talent is widely distributed but opportunity is not. I practice universal design: extensive scaffolding paired with high expectations, through worked examples before independent problem sets, multiple modes of engagement (code-alongs, small-group labs, written policy memos), and low-stakes formative assessments that catch struggling students early. When I supervised undergraduate research at Tribhuvan University and mentored students in quantitative methods, I saw how structured mentorship converts preparation gaps into research strengths. My classrooms are places where a first-generation student and a student with prior programming experience both find a path to mastery.

Methodological Transparency

I demystify research by sharing failed analyses alongside successes. When students see that a published paper survived three misspecified models and a data pipeline that broke at 2 a.m., they

learn that rigor is a process, not a gift. In my computational courses I live-code — including debugging in front of the class — so students internalize that error messages are information, not verdicts. This transparency builds the resilience independent researchers need.

Policy Communication

Every regression tells a story about people's lives, and I train students to tell it. My courses require translating technical results into accessible policy briefs and presentations for non-technical audiences — the same skill my CDC Foundation work demands when briefing ministries of health and CDC scientists. Graduates of my courses can do two things: produce credible causal evidence, and make a decision-maker act on it.

Courses Prepared to Teach

Undergraduate: Health Economics; Public Health Policy & Economics; Applied Econometrics for Public Policy; Agricultural Economics. *Master's:* Advanced Health Economics; Health Technology Assessment & Decision Modeling; Quantitative Methods for Health Policy Research; Food & Nutrition Economics; Agricultural Policy. *Doctoral:* Empirical Methods in Health Economics; Large-Scale Data Analysis for Health Research; Seminar in Applied Health Economics.

Mentoring

I mentor toward independence: undergraduates through independent studies and honors theses; master's students through applied project supervision and professional connections; doctoral students through dissertation guidance, co-authorship, and job-market preparation. My goal for every mentee is the same: a researcher who can identify an important question, marshal the right data and methods, and communicate the answer to those who need it.

Teaching, for me, is capacity building at every scale — from a first-year undergraduate meeting regression for the first time to a ministry economist building her country's first cost-effectiveness model. I am eager to bring that mission to a faculty role.